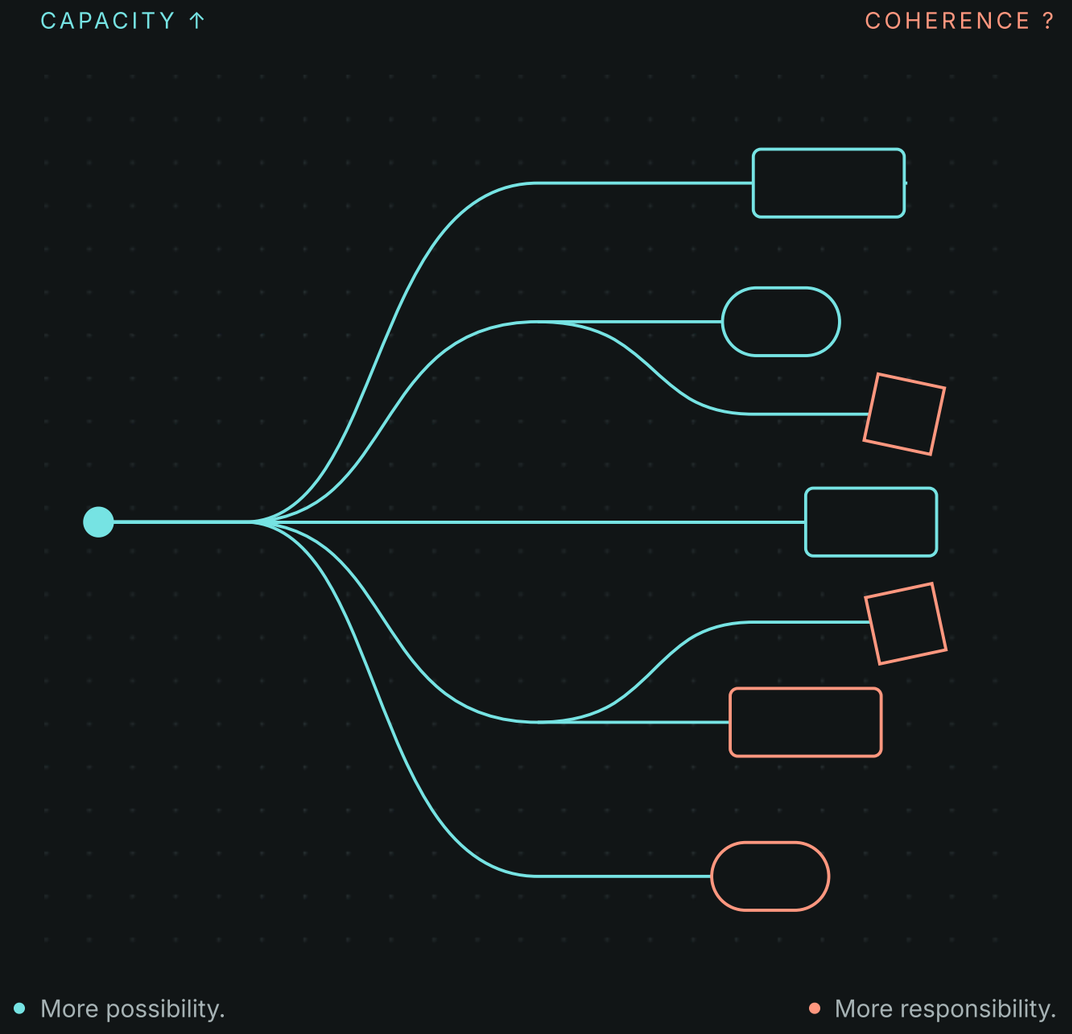
AI makes us faster. Who keeps us coherent?

Governance, systems, and the new role of DesignOps in product teams



The AI production floor is everywhere.



Product

- Brief
- Requirements
- Hypotheses



Research

- Synthesis
- Insights
- Questions



Design

- Concepts
- Prototypes
- Patterns



Engineering

- Components
- Code
- Tests

The bottleneck moves: **production → alignment → quality.**

At work

Photo to come

Movement

Photo to come

Music + drawing

Photo to come

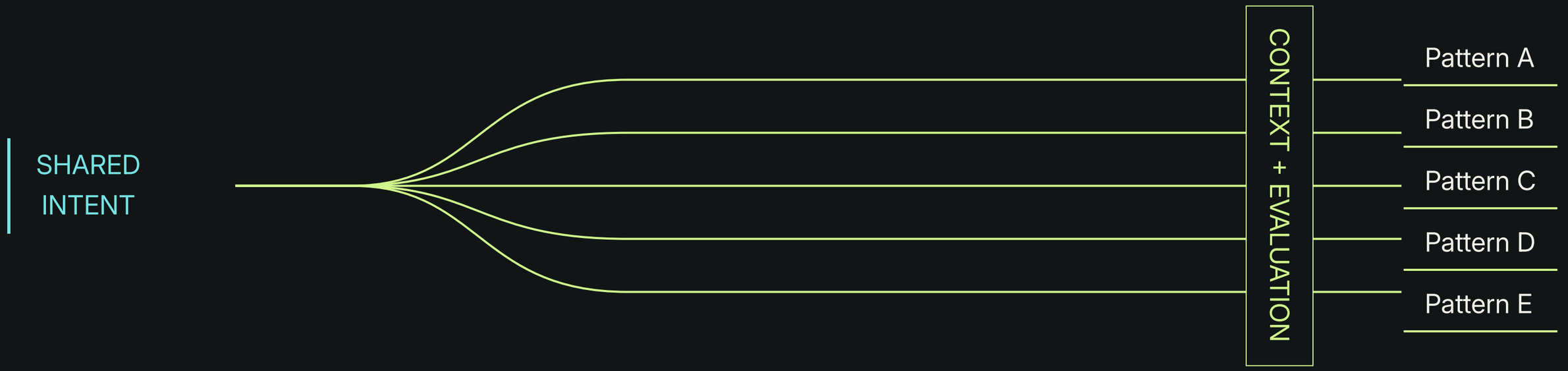
Julian Alvarado

Xbox Design Ops

- Senior Program Manager and Design Operations leader at Microsoft. Better systems, clearer processes, responsible AI for Xbox Design.
- Across teams and studios: plan, learn, deliver. Resilient, people-centered creative organizations.
- Daily CrossFit. Jiu-jitsu “forever blue belt.” Retired musician; live shows and drawing at home.
- In rotation: Radiohead, Lenny Kravitz, Oasis, Crosses.

AI doesn't just accelerate work. It accelerates variation.

More output → More variation → More decisions → More inconsistency



Distinct ideas. Shared constraints. Accountable decisions.

Three questions.
One coherent system.

GOVERN

What should we use and how should we use it?

CONTEXT

The intelligence layer for the right choices.

EVALUATE

What makes it good enough?

Fix the form. Keep the lesson.

STEP 6 OF 6

Check the next result

Can the next person start alone?

The next proposed form

Workspace name first. Invitations optional.

The review

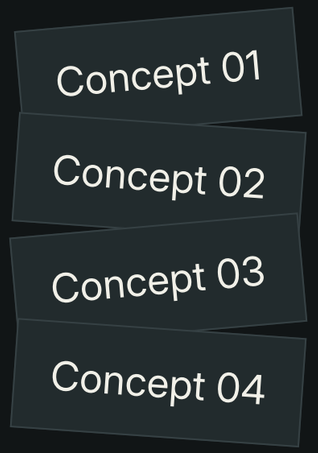
Setup works without a teammate email.

Still to check

Accessibility and whether it works for real users.

This requirement is met. The review is not over.

Many possible outputs.
One accountable judgment.



Possibility is abundant.

→

SHARED QUALITY RUBRIC

- ☐ System compliance
- ☐ User needs
- ☐ Accessibility
- ☐ Brand
- ☐ Product strategy
- ☐ Engineering feasibility

Evidence + checks + expert critique

→

Human decision

Accept, revise, or reject—with reasons.

OWNERSHIP STAYS HUMAN

Automated checks inform judgment. **They do not prove a design is good.**

Don't just save the output. Capture the learning.

Keep the decision and its reason.
Share them with the next team.

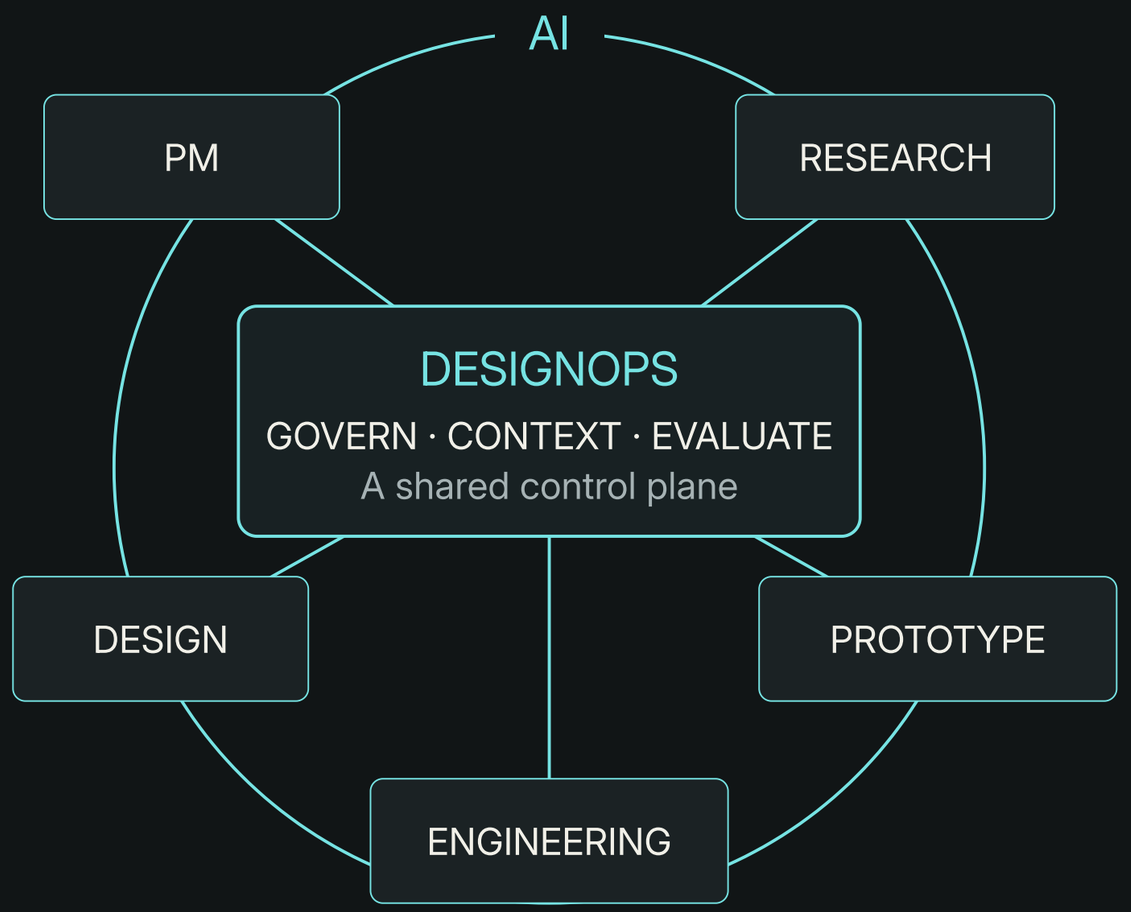
1. AI proposes a design — using shared guidance
2. The team reviews it — against the user's need
3. Save the lesson — decision + reason + owner
4. Update the guidance — for the next team + AI
5. Check the next result — do not assume success

Same foundations.
A larger operating system.

FOUNDATION	TRADITIONAL FOCUS	EXPANDED AI-ERA SCOPE
PEOPLE	Enable designers	→ Enable product teams
PROCESS	Optimize workflows	→ Architect human–AI workflows
	Measure efficiency	→ Measure quality + outcomes
	Facilitate consistency	→ Govern generated variation
SYSTEMS	Document processes	→ Encode organizational knowledge
	Scale design systems	→ Make systems AI-readable

Not doing all the work. Connecting the system.

DesignOps defines the conditions under which the work happens.



Domain experts still own product decisions.

Before accelerated production. Work moves by handoff.

Sequential handoffs

SIMPLIFIED BEFORE

Research → Brief → Mocks → Build → Release

Customer need → handoff → wait → handoff → wait → customer feedback

Less waiting.
More learning, together.

Shared purpose → synchronized work → AI-assisted production

Shared intent. Joint execution.

Mission · Milestones · Metrics	→	Spec ↔ concept ↔ HTML/CSS	→	Experiment ↔ learn

Customer need → PM + research + design + engineering → customer feedback

Hypothesis: production can shrink; experimentation can expand. Validate it.

Explore the 30-day pilot ↗

Your next infrastructure is already in your documentation.

DOCUMENTATION · INPUTS		REUSABLE GUIDANCE · OUTPUTS
Guidelines	→	Machine-readable rules
Design system	→	Scalable Production Pipeline
Documentation	→	Reusable context packages
Critique	→	Evaluation rubrics

→

PACKAGED CONTEXT FOR AI

Lesson · solo setup

Invitations after setup

Reason · from the brief

The person may be starting alone.

Owner · product lead

Version 1, reviewed by the team

Review · after pilot / change

User test pending

Faster is not the whole score.

Metric / unit	Baseline	Pilot	Change
WORKFLOW OUTCOME			
Brief → validated concept median elapsed days	9d	6d	−3 d
Design production rate accepted artifacts / in a team with 8w E2E Cycle	~3–4/wk	~1–2/wk	≈−2/wk Midpoint estimate
LEADING / PROCESS			
Review effort person-hours / accepted concept	4h	6h	+2 h
Design-system compliance % applicable checks passed	78%	90%	+12 pp

If AI becomes part of how we design products,

who designs the system in which AI operates?

DesignOps.

AI doesn't eliminate the need for DesignOps.
It makes DesignOps infrastructure.

AI creates **capacity.**

Systems create **consistency.**

Stewardship creates **trust.**

DESIGNOPS AS AI INFRASTRUCTURE

Let's talk.

LinkedIn · alvaradolj1 ↗

GitHub · JulianAlvarado ↗

View the presentation

confops26.vercel.app

01 Who owns governance? ↗

02 Do we become an AI team? ↗

03 What is an AI-ready design system? ↗

04 What happens when models change? ↗

05 How do we prove value? ↗

06 How does the context stack fit? ↗

07 Where does this fit in the lifecycle? ↗

08 How do we start a pilot? ↗

↖ BACK TO Q&A

Shared governance.
Explicit decision rights.

BOUNDARIES

Security + Legal

Data, privacy, risk, and policy.
Set non-negotiable constraints.

ACCESS

IT + platform teams

Approved technology and access.
Maintain secure capabilities.

OPERATING MODEL

DesignOps

Translate policy into workflows.
Facilitate context and evaluation.

PRODUCT JUDGMENT

Domain experts

PM, research, design, engineering.
Own quality and release decisions.

Good governance pre-approves safe paths—not every individual click.

↖ BACK TO Q&A

Architect the environment. Don't become the AI factory.

Governance
Rules + risk

Design intelligence
Consumable knowledge

Workflow architecture
With domain experts

Quality systems
Rubrics + evidence

Enablement
Playbooks + training

Measurement
Quality + outcomes

ENABLE DIFFERENT KINDS OF WORK

Prototype → Build → Improve → Grow → Maintain

Exploration, production, simplification, experimentation, and reliability need different controls.

↖ BACK TO Q&A

A component library with the reasoning attached.

KEEP THE FOUNDATION

- Tokens
- Components
- Patterns
- Guidelines

+

MAKE IT CONSUMABLE

- Semantic metadata
- Usage rules + constraints
- Examples + code equivalents
- Evaluation criteria

SHARED CONTEXT	Owner	Version	Source	Freshness	Access

Start with one pattern: its intent, code, valid uses, forbidden uses, and checks.

↖ BACK TO Q&A

Models change.
Your operating principles endure.

KNOWLEDGE	RULES	WORKFLOWS	EVALUATION

Model A ↔ Model B ↔ Model C

Re-run evaluation before switching.
Model-agnostic does not mean behavior-identical.

Canonical prompts encode domain knowledge—not one person's clever phrasing.

Co-author with PMs, researchers, designers, and engineers.
Version context, permissions, examples, and acceptance criteria together.

Measure the workflow.
Not the number of prompts.

Operational definitions for a scoped baseline and pilot

Metric	Definition / unit	Collection method
Brief → validated concept	Median elapsed days; fixed validation criteria	Brief timestamp → review + user evidence
Design production rate	Accepted artifacts per team-week	Same artifact class, scope, and acceptance rubric
Production / review effort	Person-hours per accepted concept; report separately	Time log including critique + validation
Rework / revision rate	% reviewed artifacts requiring a major revision	Revision log; agree “major” before starting
System compliance	% applicable design-system checks passed	Token, component, and interaction-pattern audit
Accessibility / quality defects	Open defects per 10 reviewed screens + severity	Manual and automated checks, deduplicated
Design-to-code divergence	% audited UI instances violating approved intent	Paired design/code review of a defined sample
Experimentation / reuse	Completed experiments/week; % work citing approved context	Decision log; context provenance in artifacts

Match scope + staffing. Record sample size + spread. Audit sampling bias. Track customer task success separately.
Small pilots are directional—not causal proof. Set adoption / revise / stop criteria before seeing results.

↖ BACK TO Q&A

The advantage isn't the model. It's the memory.

What does your organization allow the model to know?

05 **DesignOps**
Connects the system · enables adoption

04 **Stewardship**
Guardrails · exclusions · human checkpoints

03 **Organizational context**
Tokens · components · research · brand · accessibility
Terminology · workflows · repos · product experiences

02 **Agents + tools**
Design assistants · coding agents · research tools

01 **Models**
Replaceable capabilities, not institutional knowledge

↖ BACK TO Q&A

Same infrastructure.
Every stage of the journey.

01	02	03	04	05
DISCOVER	DEFINE	DESIGN	BUILD	MEASURE
Synthesize research	Frame the problem	Explore concepts	Generate components	Interpret outcomes

SHARED INFRASTRUCTURE — GOVERN — CONTEXT — EVALUATE

↖ Back to shared production

One workflow.
Thirty days. A measurable pilot.

DAYS 01–07

Map

A map of AI use, gaps, and risk.

DAYS 08–14

Select

One workflow with shared context.

DAYS 15–21

Define

A review plan: owner, criteria, baseline.

DAYS 22–30

Pilot

Comparable work, reviewed evidence.

THEN DECIDE **Adopt** / **Revise** / **Stop**